

1587. Her mother, brother, and younger sister were singers; her father Giulio Caccini, a celebrated composer and teacher, was one of the leading musicians of his day who had links to influential figures via his employment at the court of the Medici, Europe's most powerful family.

A family ensemble

When Francesca was six, her mother died and her father was left with three young children and a teenage son. The following year, 1594, he married another singer, 18-year-old Margherita della Scalain. The women of the household (Francesca, her younger sister, Settimia, and her stepmother) began singing professionally in a family ensemble. Francesca made her first professional, public appearance with this group in 1600, at the age of 13, in Jacopo Peri's opera *Euridice*.

A gifted, hugely intelligent child (and with a career as a musician clearly in the sights of her ambitious family), Francesca had been trained in guitar, lute, harp, keyboard, voice, and composition at an early age—to significant effect: in 1605, she was offered lucrative work as a singer by the court of Henry IV. However, Grand Duke Ferdinand of Tuscany, keen to retain her exceptional talent within the Medici court, refused her permission to leave Florence.

Confined in this way, Caccini had little option but to follow the career path of her father. In 1607, she started work at the Medici court, where she was to remain for the next 20 years as a teacher, singer, and composer of chamber and stage music (see [box](#)). Within seven years, she had become the court's best-paid